

"I LISTEN TO ALL MY MINISTERIAL COLLEAGUES, GIVE RESPECT AND ENSURE FAIR TREATMENT. ANYONE CAN MEET ME AT ANY TIME, INCLUDING MLAs"

Q. There is a perception that you are a novice. How are you tackling ministers senior to you?
They are all colleagues. I listen to them, give respect and ensure fair treatment. Anyone can meet me any time, including MLAs. On the charge of being a novice, as someone who has been a party office-bearer at every level for three decades, I can say that in politics, if you have an ideology and if you work to fulfil public responsibilities, you can succeed.

Q. What would you say is your vision for Rajasthan?
We have enough land. If we get water and electricity, we will have flourishing industry, tourism, agriculture, what not. With the Centre's help, I have signed agreements with neighbouring states to get extra water for the Eastern River Canal project and Yamuna waters that will come from the Tajewala barrage in Haryana. Soon we will get it for Indira Gandhi canal from Pong Dam. I've put in place the Dewas Aravali project for Udaipur. In electricity, we have signed MoUs with the Centre for generation and getting additional power with an investment of Rs 1.60 lakh crore.

Also, our cities are exploding due to the influx of rural populations. They are primarily coming for better infrastructure. I aim to expand rural facilities—electricity, water, roads, education, health—and remove the need for this exodus. I have also told collectors and SDMs to draw up a list of pending cases, village-wise, to solve these at the doorstep. Presently, they keep giving dates to the poor, forcing costly visits to government offices on them.

Q. How is your approach different from that of the Congress?
The Congress had five-year plans. By the time they were executed, fresh demands came up to expand projects. My endeavour—and I've picked this up from the Modi government—is to have works keeping in mind the next 20-25 years. Be it road width, pipeline diameters for drinking water or sewerage, or hospital capacity, the idea is always to think long-term.

Q. But you have inherited a heavily debt-ridden state. Where will you get the money to implement such long-term projects?
I am obviously not spending money in one go. Projects will be completed in stages.

Q. What steps have you taken to help people directly?
We reduced and standardised petrol and diesel prices considerably—there were variations among districts. Also, pumps in border districts were shutting down because of cheaper fuel across. All that has stopped.

Q. So, politics comes easily to you?
Politics is a double-edged sword and we walk on its edges. I am trying to emulate Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has forced a change in the way ministers, MPs and MLAs work by making them frequent their constituencies and assigned areas. I travel a lot on the ground and expect my ministers as well as senior officials to regularly assess ground implementation.

Q. Your predecessors Vasundhara Raje and Ashok Gehlot did not see eye to eye for some 15 years, never sat over a cup of tea even. But you have met with both. Why?
Politics and ideology is one thing, having personal communication another. I like restraint in the language we use against opponents. I made a courtesy call to Gehlot upon taking over and now, when he has been bed-ridden for a while. Raje is a senior leader of the party and ex-chief minister. When my father suffered an injury, both called me to inquire about him.

Q. Does that mean you will be soft in investigating the scam allegations against the Gehlot regime, such as the Kota riverfront, that your party had made a big issue of before elections?
Let me make it very clear. Anyone who has done a wrong must be punished, and will be, whosoever he or she may be.

Q. You stumbled at your first electoral hurdle, the general election. Now you face a major byelection challenge: five seats where Opposition MLAs went on to win Lok Sabha seats.
The Lok Sabha result has been analysed at various levels and will require another long sitting to discuss. Our party will leave no stone unturned in the bypolls.

Q. Has life as a CM changed your daily routine?
If you go by work hours, not much. As a party office-bearer, I often travelled by night. Even when at Jaipur HQ, I would leave for home at midnight. I still do that. ■